DECO3500 Early User Testing Plan

Project: Pally — A Discord Bot for Better Social Gameplay
Research Topic: Social Compliance in Gaming
Course: DECO6500

1. Research Objectives

To observe and understand how Pally's three tools (Random Pick, Trait Picker, and Excuse Generator) interact with or influence social compliance in group gaming contexts.

Previous interviews (Affinity Map V2.0) identified three themes related to social compliance:

Theme	Corresponding Tool	Focus of Observation
Power to Decide	Random Pick	How decision-making power is distributed within the group and what patterns emerge.
Power to Evaluate	Trait Picker	What patterns emerge in how group members evaluate one another through an anonymous mechanism.
Power to Say No	Excuse Generator	How members express their desire to refuse or leave, and how social costs are reflected in these interactions.

2. Theoretical Framework: Groupware Heuristics

This study adopts the eight groupware heuristics proposed by Baker, Greenberg, and Gutwin (2001), based on the Mechanics of Collaboration, as analytical dimensions for observing and coding real interaction data:

- Provide the means for intentional and appropriate verbal communication
- Provide the means for intentional and appropriate gesture communication
- Provide consequential communication of an individual's embodiment
- Provide consequential communication of shared artifacts
- Provide protection
- Measurement of tightly and loosely-coupled collaboration
- Allow people to coordinate their actions
- Facilitate finding collaborators and establishing contacts

3. Participants

- One group of five participants who regularly play games together and are familiar with some group members, rather than a group of strangers.

4. Session Design

Conduct one real gameplay session with the following conditions:

- Session A: Participants play without using Pally.
- Session B: Participants play with Pally, with all three tools running in the background as intended.

- If the prototype is not yet complete, a Wizard of Oz approach may be used, with team members manually simulating tool messages and triggers.
- Audio will be recorded throughout the session, with participants' consent.

5. Scenario-Based Task Design

To observe how participants actually use the tools, a few scenario-based tasks are designed.

- **Random Pick — Map Selection Scenario**: Before the game starts, each of the 3 participants is privately told (via note or DM) a different map preference (A insists on Map A, B on Map B, C on Map C). When the group discussion hits a deadlock, observe whether they actually use Random Pick to break the tie, or fall back on the old pattern of just going along with whoever speaks loudest.
- **Trait Picker — Post-Game Feedback Scenario**: Participants are told to give feedback on their teammates' performance after the game, without being told how to do it. Observe whether the group stays silent, gives verbal feedback, or uses Trait Picker.
- **Excuse Generator — Early Exit Scenario**: One participant is given the scenario of "needing to leave partway through the game," and their way of exiting is observed.

6. In-situ Observation

- Three team members will observe the session while remaining in the voice channel with their microphones muted.
- Participants will be informed in advance that observers will be present, but the specific research questions will not be disclosed.
- Brief notes with timestamps will be taken during the session to help locate key interaction moments during later analysis.

7. Coding

- Each of the three team members will independently review the recordings of Sessions A and B in full and code the interactions against the eight heuristics listed in Section 2.
- Coding categories: Present / Absent / Constrained / N/A.
- Team members will complete their coding independently without discussing their decisions with one another.

Heuristic	Session A	Session B	Evidence (Timestamp)
1. Provide the means for intentional and appropriate verbal communication			
2. Provide the means for intentional and appropriate gesture communication			
3. Provide consequential communication of an individual's embodiment			
4. Provide consequential communication of shared artifacts			
5. Provide protection			
6. Measurement of tightly and loosely-coupled collaboration			
7. Allow people to			

coordinate their actions			
8. Facilitate finding collaborators and establishing contacts			

- After coding is completed, the team will hold a discussion to review items with significant differences in coding.

8. Interviews

Each participant will be interviewed for 5–10 minutes after the session.

- “With Trait Picker, everyone could give feedback about someone without saying who they were. Would you say the same things to them in person?”
- “If you didn’t have Excuse Generator, what would you do if you wanted to leave?”
- “When you used Random Pick, did the decisions feel fair? How was it different from the way you usually make decisions as a group?”
- “During the game, did these tools change how you went along with the group? And why?”
- “If you were playing with people you didn’t know very well, would you use these tools in the same way? Especially the ones for saying no or giving feedback?”

8. Ethics

- Participants will be informed in advance that observers will be present.
- All audio recordings, video recordings, and anonymous evaluation content will be de-identified.